reports of growing factionalism within his party. The delay in cabinet expansion and the possibility of having to yield more to senior ally BJP is also causing unease among legislators who crossed over for ministerial berths. Old Sena cadre also say the sense of being under siege has led to party workers and core voters closing ranks with the Thackerays. "We gained sympathy when our government was toppled," says a source in the Thackeray camp. "It had been dissipating. The EC decision has revived the sentiment."

A veteran Sainik from central Mumbai cites another fact the Thackeray camp can take heart from. "This is not the first time a party has lost its symbol," he says. "It had happened to the Congress under Indira too. Besides voter and cadre sympathy, our USP is the Thackeray legacy... In India, people support personalities, not ideologies." And Shinde, he believes, just does not have Uddhav's stature. They believe the residuary party has enough steam in it, especially in India's financial capital.

Mumbai's politics is polarised along linguistic lines, between Marathi and non-Marathi speakers—while not a majority, the former are its largest minority. And though no caste, religious or linguistic group votes as a monolith, old Sena loyalties still move the Maharashtrian working class. Its ground-level *shakha* connect also extends to non-Marathi zones: Gujaratis, Jains, Marwaris and South Indians, besides Muslims and Christians. Uddhav's test will lie in whether he can blend his softer, cosmopolitan instincts with the Sena's old nativist credo, widening his catchment area without harming the core. Also, that inherent contradiction applies perhaps more starkly to the Shinde-BJP alliance. The latter's base lies largely among Jains, Gujaratis, Marwaris and North Indians—all have fraught ties with old Sena voters. None of this diminishes the huge task before the Uddhav camp. If the EC allocates them a new name and symbol, they will have to first popularise it—even so, voters might press the old symbol by force of habit. "Overall, we have no option but to fight a legal battle and reach out to voters," says the veteran leader.

UDDHAV WILL NOW HAVE TO APPROACH COURTS AND TAP INTO THE WAVE OF SYMPATHY FOR HIM

And while Uddhav may enjoy some popular sympathy at present, a senior Congress leader says it's still up to him to tap into this sentiment and encash it by hitting the ground running. Senior journalist Nikhil Wagle, too, says Uddhav's future depends on how he translates sentiment into votes. His gentle, white-collar leadership did see many of the Sena's rough edges being smoothed out, but Uddhav may have to return to the rough-and-ready, muscular street politics the party was once known for. He may also have to groom grassroots leaders and those with a mass base, shedding the high command mode.

And therein lies the rub. As a close Shinde aide notes, Bal Thackeray doted on his Sainiks, and elicited a strong sense of personal loyalty. Uddhav has yet to build the same sense of personal loyalty around him. After all, it was he who had personally groomed Shinde and many of his fellow rebels, men who finally walked out on him. ■



RANJAN RAHI

BIHAR

THE KUSHWAHA CAPER

By Amitabh Srivastava

The week after Valentine's Day came the news of a breakup in Bihar. Upendra Kushwaha, self-appointed younger brother of Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, quit the primary membership of the Janata Dal (United)—which he had joined only in March 2021—to float his own Rashtriya Lok Janata Dal (RLJD) and is dropping broad hints on the possibility of joining hands with the BJP-led NDA, which Nitish had left in August 2022. Though the Lok Sabha election is more than a year away, this marks one more turning point in Bihar's intense political flux. Given ambitious movers and shakers like Nitish and Kushwaha, the pre-electoral cauldron has already started bubbling in the state.

If Nitish on February 18 urged the Congress to immediately initiate dialogue with potential partners for a proposed anti-BJP political front, Kushwaha switched gears two days later to leave the JD(U). While he himself did not reveal all his cards at his press conference in Patna, the Bihar BJP let the cat out of the bag, when its spokesman Nikhil Anand tweeted within hours of Kushwaha's presser to